10. From Maritime Supremacy to Continental Isolation: China under the Yuan and Ming Dynasties

The thirteenth century saw China fall entirely under the rule of the alien Mongol Yuan dynasty, which lasted for over 100 years (1227–1368 CE). The other non-Han dynasties of the Jin (1115–1234 CE) and the Xi Xia (1038–1227 CE), which had been ruling northern and western China, were defeated by the Mongols, who had begun to venture out of the Mongolian steppes as an inexorable conquering force under Genghis Khan. The Xi Xia fell under Mongol rule in 1227 CE , while the territories of the Jin became part of the Mongol empire in 1234 CE . With the defeat of the Southern Song by the Mongol leader Kublai Khan, the Mongols established control over virtually the entire territory of China.

The Southern Song ruled over the region south of the Yangzi river from 1127 CE to 1276 CE when they were defeated by Kublai Khan in a major naval battle in the Pearl River delta. The Yuan navy was led by a Chinese admiral who had earlier served the Song. Remnants of the Southern Song lingered on in pockets of southern China until 1279, when the whole of China fell under Mongol rule. This was the first time in Chinese history that the entire territory of China, and much besides, fell under alien rule. Mongol rule was a prelude to another, more extended period of alien rule under the Manchus, successors to the Jurchen tribes who conquered China in 1644 and ruled the country till 1911. Despite large parts or even the whole of China having been ruled by alien dynasties for nearly half of the country’s recorded history, in the current ‘Sinicized’ version of this history, successive dynasties have been merged into one another in a neat, continual and linear pattern.

Despite their origins from the open steppes, the Mongols continued to